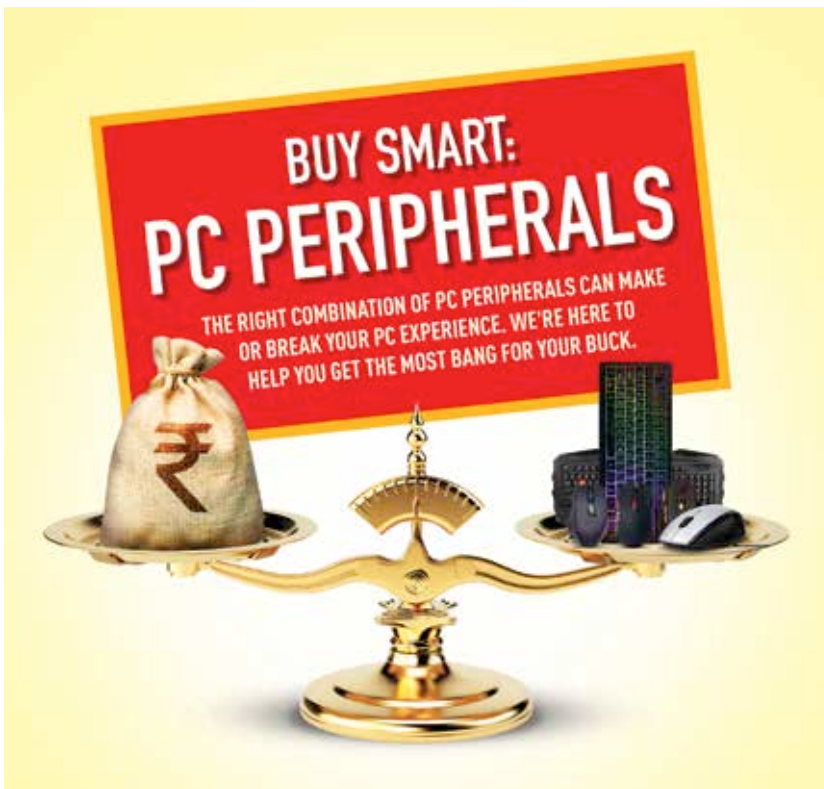




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KEYBOARDS

While most gadgets can be objectively scored, keyboards heavily rely on personal preference. You might prefer a feature-rich keyboard with RGB and hotkeys, or maybe a no-frills keyboard with a brilliant typing experience is more your style. And if you have never thought of it in that way, it's time to start.

In the market today, you'll find membrane keyboards, mechanical keyboards, and now even hybrid and optical-mechanical keyboards. You're really spoiled for choice. Let's explore the choices.

Membrane

There's nothing wrong with good old membrane, or rubber dome keyboards. While they may not be



HP K500F Membrane Keyboard

as durable as mechanical keyboards, they're far cheaper. The trade off here, in addition to durability and longevity, is that many prefer the typing experience on mechanical keyboards over membrane keyboards. Ultimately, this still comes down to personal preference, and for these situations, hands-on experience is the best. However, your cheapest option when it comes to keyboards, is to get your hands on a membrane keyboard. It should more than suffice for general everyday keyboard needs, but keep in mind that they're not built for intense typing or gaming sessions, as the membrane tends to start flattening and wearing out.

In our opinion you should pass on hybrid or mem-chemical keyboards. They're essentially membrane keyboards that feel like mechanical keyboards, but cost about as much as the cheapest mechanical keyboards anyway.

Mechanical keyboards

When picking a mechanical keyboard, your priority is the switch type. You've got linear, tactile and clicky switches. All of which feel dif-

ferent to type on. Then you have the actuation, or force required to actually register switch presses. The combination of these two factors allows for a myriad of switch possibilities. The most popular mechanical switch brand is Cherry, but in addition to that you have brand specific switches, such as Razer, HyperX and Logitech's Romer-G for example. Then there are cheaper brands, such as Kailh and Outemu, which have a design that's very similar to Cherry. Today, the market is at such a point that even the cheaper brands offer almost as much durability as Cherry or brand-specific switches. It's incredibly easy to find a cheap mechanical keyboard that uses Kailh or Outemu switches. Even the typing experience, as long as you're comparing similar types of switches, i.e., Cherry MX Blues and Kailh Blues, doesn't differ too much. This means that you can safely go for the cheaper option if you have budget constraints.

The benefit of going with more established brands is the software support and customer care that comes with the products themselves. Naturally, these things come at a higher price point.

You can get your hands on a cheap mechanical keyboard from brands like Cosmic Byte or Zebronics for as little as ₹1,500. But keep in mind that these will most likely be TKL or 60% keyboards, i.e., they don't have numpads. Additionally, like we mentioned above, don't expect any additional software support with these keyboards as well.



Cosmic Byte Firefly

If you're looking for the *crème de la crème* of mechanical keyboards, then you probably want to opt for a Corsair keyboard, specifically the K100, which comes with Cherry MX Speed keys. This will set you back by a significant amount, but it comes with every feature imaginable on a mechanical keyboard.